

WORKSHEET

Before the face of God

Torah: Leviticus 16:1–34 · **Haftarah:** Isaiah 57:14–58:14 · **Gospel:** Matthew 25:31–46

Yom Kippur begins not with our experience but with God's holiness: Aaron draws near in God's way, receives atonement first for himself, and the guilt is carried away — “before the LORD you shall be clean.” Isaiah 58 unmasks a fast that stays mere form, and Matthew 25 tests the fruit: whoever truly lives from atonement cannot let the least become invisible. Hebrews 9–10 points to Yeshua, the High Priest who by His own blood appears “in the presence of God for us.”

How to use this sheet

Work from top to bottom: first observe (A1), then weigh (A2), then diagnose (A3), and only then summarise (A4). The direction — receiving or grasping — is the horizon, not the starting point.

Basic data

Parashah / scope: Yom Kippur — Leviticus 16:1–34. Haftarah: Isaiah 57:14–58:14. Flanking reading and status: Matthew 25:31–46 — New Testament reflection, used confessionally (not as peshat). Audience: study group / congregation.

A1. Text blocks and peshat

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keywords / contrast	Open question
16:1–14	Drawing near not self-evident; first atonement for the priest himself.	holiness · first for himself	Do I begin with myself or with another?

16:15–22	Sanctuary cleansed; two goats; guilt confessed and carried away.	cleanse · carry away	What does God do with confessed guilt?
16:29–34	Affliction and sabbath rest; “clean before the LORD”.	affliction + rest	Must I save myself, or receive?
Isa. 58	A fast that stays form vs. justice, bread, clothing the naked; justice and sabbath.	form ↔ justice	Does my form carry the message or hide it?
Matt. 25:31–46	Sheep/goats on the treatment of the least = of Yeshua.	the least · surprise	What does my treatment of the vulnerable show?

A2. Connecting hypotheses

Hypothesis 1 (one axis): the centre is Source alone — atonement is God’s work, the human receives; treatment of the neighbour stays background.

Hypothesis 2 (relation): the centre is Source ↔ Coherence — God gives the atonement (before His face), and that received atonement becomes visible in how we treat the least (Isa. 58 / Matt. 25).

Which explains the most data with the least strain? Hypothesis 2. It explains why the sanctuary itself is cleansed (sin touches the community), why Isaiah ties fasting to justice, and why Matt. 25 is chosen as the test. Hypothesis 1 leaves the haftarah and the gospel dangling.

What would refute this reading? If the fruit (the neighbour) were to replace the root (God’s atonement) — then it would become works-righteousness, which is exactly what Lev. 16 reverses.

A3. Four axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	16:2,16,30 · Heb. 9:12,24	Load-bearing. God is holy and gives the atonement.	Why nearness only along this way?

Coherence	16:16 · Isa. 58:6–7 · Matt. 25:40	Load-bearing. Inner (atoned) ↔ outer (the least).	Where does “seeing the other” become achievement?
Will	16:29–31 · Isa. 58:6	Response: humble, rest, receive.	Where does affliction become a project?
Trajectory	Teruah → Shuvah → Kippur · Heb. 9–10	Serving. The feasts run out here; fulfilment in Yeshua.	Pointer or core?

A4. Movement

What is unmasked? Religious pride (drawing near as a judge), and form cut off from life — fasting while you oppress someone, praying while you refuse to forgive; and the anxious holding-on to guilt (your own and another’s).

What frame does the text put in its place? Standing before the face of God: He is holy, gives the atonement and carries the guilt away — and then teaches us to live as people who have received from atonement.

What concrete response and formation follow? Humble and rest (not saving yourself); bring the form back to justice (Isa. 58); and do not let the least become invisible (Matt. 25) — including the question: whom must I treat differently because I myself live from atonement?

Core sentence: Before His face everything falls away but this — He is holy, He carries the guilt away; and whoever receives that can no longer let the other stay invisible.

Horizon (ground, not the week’s theme): Yeshua, the High Priest who by His own blood appears “in the presence of God for us” (Heb. 9–10) — the pattern points, it does not flatten Leviticus 16.